assembly on a Monday morning and award you a wooden plaque with a ball mounted on top. The problem was that I was scoring so many runs that they eventually had to stop giving me the award. It was a little embarrassing for all concerned, I think. So ja, by then I was beginning to understand that maybe I was a bit better than other kids my age.

I was 11 when I first saw my name appear in the *Cape Argus*. Legendary Cape Town sportswriter AC Parker had written a report on the SA Perm Week – basically the national under-13 cricket tournament. The headline read: 'Herschelle's star on the rise'. My dad still has that clipping in his scrapbook. It was my first year at Perm Week – I was in Standard 4 (now Grade 6) then. I played for Western Province again the following year, in my final year at primary school.

It was in high school though that I really started making a name for myself, and not only in schoolboy sport, but at senior level as well. I was offered a scholarship by Bishops, an exclusive private school, after John Peake, the headmaster, had noticed my sporting abilities, and I started there in Standard 6.

I think I was on a full day-scholarship; I never asked my dad about the financial side of it, but I do know that he could never have afforded to send me there. My dad had struggled to afford St Joseph's, let alone Bishops.

But I didn't just excel at cricket; I was making a name for myself as a rugby player too. I think playing rugby had a lot to do with my scholarship, as school rugby was, and remains, a big deal at Bishops. But the big deal for *me* back then was neither cricket nor rugby. Football was my favourite sport and the one at which I reckoned I was most talented. I was already playing provincial football at that age.

So, in winter I'd play a rugby game for my school and then rush off to play club football, aware of the fact that my team was deliberately delaying the start of the game so that I could make the kick-off.

I loved Bishops. I always felt completely at home there and, despite the fact that I was neither white nor wealthy (unlike the majority of my fellow learners), I never for a moment felt like I didn't belong. The sports field helped overcome any social barriers there might have been and I made a lot of friends quite quickly. The guys gravitated towards me once they saw how good I was at sport. I've always had an outgoing personality, and I think I'm easy to get along with, so that helped too. It is very rare that I don't feel comfortable in company and, irrespective of who the people are, I am